

Planning an Affordable Wedding

According to *Brides Magazine*, the average wedding in the United States costs around \$26,500. How can you keep your wedding costs under control? First of all, do a budget. Make a list of everything you can think of that you'll need for the ceremony, rehearsal dinner, and reception and your estimate of what each item will cost. Refine your budget as you get price quotes, and identify the things that are most important to you. Small compromises can often add up to big savings.



Tipping is often an overlooked wedding expense that could bust your budget. Don't forget to plan for tipping caterers, limo drivers, parking attendants, and musicians 10 to 20 percent if you're happy with their services.

The Wedding Budget

The biggest factor influencing your costs is the number of guests that attend. If your average cost per person for food, drink, linens, cutlery, china, and other things you have to rent by the person is \$50, knocking twenty people off your guest list will save you \$1,000 plus tips.

Consider a buffet or hearty hors d'oeuvres instead of a sit-down dinner. Bar costs can be higher than food costs, and the markup on alcohol provided by your caterer is significant. It's cheaper to do it yourself but you'll have to assume the liquor liability. Talk to your insurance agent to see if your homeowner's policy will cover it. One option for limiting bar costs is to provide tickets for guests that they can turn in for drinks. If they